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Dan Wall & Adam Nussbaum

Keyboardist Dan Wall and drummer Adam Nussbaum are two of the busiest jazz artists on the current scene. They have performed and recorded with a lengthy list of artists including James Moody, Joe Lovano, Henry Mancini and Gil Evans. They have been members of the John Abercrombie Trio since 1991.

Dan and Adam were interviewed in Clinton, New York on April 19, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming at Hamilton College for the Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have two interesting personalities with me today, Adam Nussbaum and Dan Wall, who just described himself as a keyboard wizard. Is that what I heard correctly?

AN: That would be an adequate description of him for sure.

DW: There were other much better words than that, that I won't repeat.

MR: You know I'm looking at some of the information that was sent to me about you fellas and I think next time you do your resumes you could almost write down here's the people I haven't played with and you'd actually have a shorter list. It's amazing to me how many musicians that you guys have worked with. How does that come about?

AN: I think what happens is you get to New York, you have friends that you meet on the scene, they have maybe gigs and associations with people that are established, your name gets out there, people hear about you, friends recommend you, people hear you, and it kind of works that way. And being able to fulfill the requirements of jobs is one way to get another job. I mean a buddy of mine said the best way to get a gig is to have a gig. Because people hear you and then they can always find your number. And a lot of elements come into play. You know luck is I think when skill and opportunity meet.

MR: All right, that's a good description.

AN: And I think that's something I've been very fortunate to have. And I feel very blessed to have had the opportunities to play with so many great musicians, because it's a constant learning process for me.

MR: Um hum. Did it pretty much happen the same way for you, Dan?

DW: Yeah, I think what Adam said is very true, that you know you meet people, you play with them, they like your playing or they don't like your playing, but if they like your playing then they tell a friend of theirs about this person. Because they know that this person they're speaking with would enjoy a certain thing that you do, certain interaction you have with people, and you connect with them and from them you connect with somebody else. And it's, you know, hopefully you get a flow going out of it. And another thing

that's probably important too to work with a lot of people is to have developed kind of a broad understanding of music, you know, roots, so that you're, I mean you can look at someone who's a specialist and they only do one thing, but if you look at the big picture of things I think that if you can be a diverse player then your chances are much better for getting out there and working with a lot of different people because everybody's a little different.

MR: Um hum. Did you guys come out of a music education background? Maybe you can address that first.

DW: No, not so much with me. I was fortunate for one thing that I grew up in a family of professional piano players. It went back to my grandfather, my uncle is a very good pianist, my mom is still doing gigs, my two cousins, it's kind of ridiculous. You know one is a record producer and a phenomenal reader. A well educated person as opposed to me. So I was at Berklee kind of doing just some specialized piano studies as opposed to really being involved in going after a degree and participating in ensembles, I was actually doing a lot of gigs around Boston and just, you know, at the school to kind of get what I felt that I needed to get. So I didn't come out of the educational. Now I teach in colleges, which is kind of strange because I didn't go through that system. I did most of my learning really from listening, from playing with people, and by having people in the family who I could actually sit down and listen to this great sound coming out of the piano with these great chord voicings, you know, and ask my uncle, what are you doing? And then I would sit down, I want to do that, I want to make this instrument sound this way too. So that was more of my education.

MR: Yeah. How about yourself?

AN: I'd say pretty much the same thing. I didn't really come from a musical household, I came from a very arts oriented household. My father was an artist and my mother was involved with acting and graphics. And I was the sole musician. And I had a lot of different experience when I was younger, I mean I studied the piano, I studied the bass, I studied the saxophone, but I just always wanted to play drums. So I kind of taught myself how to play drums after being inspired by an older cousin. And then I was always working in little rock bands, youth symphony, marching band, things like that, and got hip to jazz when I was about 14 or 15 and pretty much did it on my own. I did go to the Davis Center for Performing Arts which is a division of City College of New York for five semesters, because basically my parents said look while you go to school we'll pay your rent. And we want you to go to school because of course we want you to be prepared. And I never finished school. Because I was in New York and I was having the opportunity to work with a lot of different people, doing a lot of little gigs for very little money, but for amazingly great wealth of experience. And I never finished school. And I

just was out on the road. Being in New York City I had the opportunity to go to jam sessions, meet a lot of older musicians and have the opportunity to really have a hands on experience. So school was to fill in more of the theoretical aspects, you know, as far as learning about music, theory, harmony, stuff like that, which unfortunately I don't know enough of. But being in New York City gave me the opportunity hands on to really learn about playing. So I'd say most of my education really comes from — the playing aspect — comes from being out there on the street more than through the academia.

MR: I recently read a statement said by the fella that you happen to be playing with tonight, that he actually, in retrospect, feels more fortunate that there wasn't all this jazz education available when he was learning. Do you have any feeling on that statement?

DW: Well I understand what this fellow meant in that, and I see it happening myself through my own teaching, that you know it's very easy for a young musician who is in the educational system and the process to become so absorbed with theoretical knowledge and the black and white on paper of this or that that they miss the real bottom line of the whole thing which is the ear and creating music. Hearing something to play. You know what I mean? It's almost like a block that can happen with some of them, not always. But maybe some of those people who are almost overloaded by theoretical information, maybe some of those people could be further along in their playing if they had approached it in a less academic way.

AN: More hands on. More hands on. I mean the best way to learn about this music is by doing it, and learning, for me, has been a constant evolution where only so much can come from books and come from things that you see. So much has to be done on the bandstand. The process of learning. Sitting next to musicians who are older and wiser, and basically getting humbled by people on the bandstand, where you basically get your ass kicked by people that play better than you and you learn through doing. And unfortunately, well unfortunately there's less opportunities for that to occur because the big bands don't exist so much, jazz is not the popular music of our time, where in the older days it was more popular, you always had the opportunity hands on through the whole mentoring reality, where you'd be with older musicians who were more knowledgeable and you'd learn by being next to them. And it's like how did you learn how to walk? You didn't read it out of a book. You saw somebody do it, and you tried to do it, you fell down, you got up, you did it again. And you learn through doing. And consequently because there are not these opportunities for young musicians as far as this mentoring opportunity, the educational system is taking up some of that slack, which is very good. But we can't lose sight of the whole reality of trying to find a voice, trying to find your own thing, your own sound. It's not like how well can I be a Xerox of somebody else, but how can I take all the elements that are out there, learn as much as I can through — imitation is part of the learning

process — but then how can I find out how I can be the best that I can be. I mean in the old days it used to be you'd listen to somebody and you could tell who they were right away, it's like they sang their own song. Now a lot of musicians it's like they're singing somebody else's song, and what's their song. You know what I mean?

MR: Do you think it ever gets to the point where, does it get harder to have your own voice because there's so many more people that have come before you?

AN: I think that as time goes on we have to realize that nobody can be, like nobody can be me better than me. And I have to tap into all my different influences and I am my own person. And the way I look at things and the way that I am establishes and helps to shape what I'm about. I have a multitude of influences. I mean who said that great line, it's like to steal from one person is plagiarism, to steal from many is research. And that's kind of what I've done. I mean I'm a product of my time. I didn't grow up playing bebop, I grew up listening to classical music and playing rock & roll. So that's all part of my roots, that's part of my Wonder Bread years. So I can't deny the fact that I was effected by Jimi Hendrix, that I love Motown, that I used to listen to Bartok and opera when I was a child. That's all part of me. So then I did a whole study of learning about jazz, my own pursuit, because I loved it, and I'm really somebody who's interested in the history of it that all these things kind of effect me. I mean certain people I love their sound, I don't dig their feel. Certain people I like their swing, but I don't really get much from the — you know I've taken different things from different people and not just drummers or musicians. Other influences of people in the arts and things like that have effected me. You know, visual things that I see. Being up here in the rolling hills influences how I think about things. Watching the clouds in the sky, an ice skater, all those things kind of effect my aesthetic viewpoint, which effects me.

MR: Who are some of the musicians you might have stolen from early on?

DW: Everybody. Only the best. Well I probably stole from some of the worst too.

AN: Or you figure out who you don't want to steal from along the way too.

DW: That's basically I think probably what happens really. That doesn't interest me, I won't steal from him. Now this over here, yes, let me grab some of that. Well you know I grew up listening to, when I really became interested in music, you know I was telling you about being from the family of pianists, I think that really actually turned me off in the beginning because I hated piano lessons. You know because everybody did that. But they were smart, after about a year they said listen, if you don't like that you don't have to do that. That's the end of that. So then when I went back to it, it was because I got interested in rock & roll. I heard Motown music, I heard the Stones, all these people, and I was dabbling with the piano because my uncle, hearing this great sound, but what I was really interested in was the guitar. Because of that music. So I started listening to guitar players,

of course all of the bands of that time, and the guitar player with James Brown and the whole smear of kind of those two kinds of music, I even had a little period of time where I listened to a lot of country music. And basically because I loved the guitar playing, I loved their sound, I loved their percussive attack and the edge they played with, and I got into a little country thing for a while. But then I kind of gravitated back to the jazz world and I was hearing Wes Montgomery. That's one of the first, I think Wes Montgomery, Kenny Burrell were two of the first people who really hit me. And around the same time I was paying attention to some piano players because of a record that was in the house and it was a record that was kind of like a variety disk with Tatum, a couple tracks by Tatum, a couple of tracks by Lenny Tristano, a couple tracks Mary Lou Williams. That was pretty amazing to hear all this. And that really kind of grabbed my ear. So it was equally split between guitar players and starting to find out about some of the piano players from that period, Errol Garner was another one. But when I heard the guitar players, especially Wes, then I started hearing Jimmy Smith, and then the organ kind of grabbed my attention. And through him I heard Larry Young and then that led to a whole path of organ players and organ trios with all those great guitar players. But at the same time I kind of kept my interest in rock & roll and Motown. I kept it all going for a while until it became really like yeah I want to play jazz. I said this is really what I feel like, this is the serious thing for me.

MR: When did you first hit on the concept of looking at a chord symbol and building something from it?

DW: Like extend—

MR: Well just the difference of actually having to play written out music.

DW: Immediately. I think because, well I say immediately not in the very beginning of listening to the Stones. When I heard that I heard guitar parts from records and I saw chord symbols. But when I heard Wes play for instance, and I heard what was happening, you know I heard lines happening, there was something more happening over this harmonic bass, that's when I wanted to do something with the chord symbol. That's when I realized you could do something creative with this, with this foundation here, and I think that's when that whole process started. And I'm still trying to find out what to do with all this.

MR: When I listen to some of your recent recordings with this particular trio you're working with with John, it really sounds like there's a lot of experimenting going on almost at every moment. Is that just inherent in the music or do you guys feel like you're really pushing the envelope of what an organ based trio can do?

DW: I think that's kind of what we tried to do from the beginning of this band really. That was the idea.

AN: I think we all are very respectful of things that have gone on before and love that, and at the same time we all like to look. I think we all have some kind of vision and I think we all have very similar common denominators as far as our musical roots and understanding, and it's like okay, we understand this and let's see how we can try to test some new waters. I don't think it was really a conscious effort, it was just kind of that we're all of a similar mind I think. We all have that similar kind of attitude about okay, let's reach. And that's just I guess an unspoken thing that we like to do. We like to take chances, take risks. And because we've kind of developed a trust of one another within this situation, these potentials are there for things to happen. Sometimes they work out, sometimes they don't, but that's all part of the fun. Taking chances, I mean taking some risks. We don't want to play it safe.

MR: Right. And you're like the bass player too.

DW: Um hum.

AN: He's the every man. He takes care of everything.

MR: I mean you have a — I can't think of the word — but you can send the thing where it's going to go.

AN: He dictates a lot of what can happen. I think within the situation we all have a little more responsibility, which comes with the freedom, meaning more responsibility. I think very harmonically also. I'm understanding always what's going on with the structures and how I can help to underline and give some kind of support to the harmonic structure of the compositions. You know not just with him but I'm helping to index those things, because there's not necessarily a bass player and a separate piano player. And if I help to do that that helps to free him at times. And we all kind of like take turns extending into other zones.

DW: Yeah it makes it, you know being the bass player, and I really feel this when I go back to the piano where I have a bass player, you know being the bass player really definitely creates more responsibility as Adam was saying, but actually I've learned to enjoy that responsibility because it gives me an ability to shape things for myself a certain way or to respond to something say Adam is doing so that it really takes a change of gears because basically you're talking about the keyboard player and the bass player and one instantly going a certain direction. We've had a lot of fun with this over the years because we can just zoom. And it's a good responsibility. And like Adam said, sometimes it works and sometimes it doesn't. But when it works I think it's an unusually good thing. And going back to when we put the band together we definitely didn't sit down and have a meeting and say listen, let's do something different than the traditional organ trio. I think that was just basically in the air when the three of us got together to play and especially started playing gigs, that was basically automatically there, that this is going to be, to play these

tunes, actually just even a great percentage of the material that we play if you played it as a traditional organ trio it wouldn't quite work. It kind of dictates that, you know, here's a piece of music—

AN: The music tells you what to do.

DW: that requires a different approach.

AN: The music really tells you what to do and then you have to figure out how to take care of it you know, just support what it tells you to do.

MR: Do you ever find that if you're let's say playing a standard or something, you're playing it in two for a while, that you feel like you want to start going in four and you prod Dan and, do you ever resist?

DW: He prods all the time.

AN: I'm the instigator. I think, well I love it when he plays two. Because once it goes to four that's kind of where it goes. You know once it hits four-four, that's where it goes to. The longer we can mess with it, the more tensions it can create, and the more options that are viable for us. You know when he plays two or he plays some kind of broken figures, similar to like just what an upright player would play or the bass you know, it gives us the opportunity. If he's playing two I can play two, I can play four, I can zip in and around, whatever, we can play around with it. Sometimes he'll instigate and go into the four, whatever. There's no set rule with that.

DW: Sometimes it could be something that John plays, we're playing in back of John. Some line just feels like yeah, there it is. No other place to go.

AN: Right. Yeah.

MR: We're committed now.

DW: Yeah.

AN: Yeah.

DW: And you know I think also for me it makes it a little easier playing because I use the lower keyboard for bass, as opposed to pedals, that it makes it easier, at least for me to create some of those shapes where it's not always just kind of like finger popping walking bass, because of things that are possible with the hand that the feet can't quite do or wouldn't naturally do. So we have a lot of fun with it.

MR: You have a pretty good percentage of original material in the trio. Is it a challenge to get your own pieces played these days, other than doing it yourself?

DW: Well the couple of organ records that I've done lately I think have been almost all my tunes but maybe a couple of standards. With this band we played some of Adam's tunes, we played a lot of my tunes which has been really nice, that from the beginning of that, I think the first record was very equal or whatever in the amount of writing. I mean John

basically has always looked for material that we would sound good playing. It doesn't matter who wrote it. If this works, fine.

AN: A very democratic band leader.

DW: That's right.

MR: That's good. Do you get pressure from the record people to include standards?

AN: Not with this band.

MR: Not with this band?

DW: That's for sure.

AN: Not with the label that we've been involved with.

MR: Oh with ECM?

AN: No.

MR: That's good.

DW: But a good example, you know that brings up a funny thing though about organ, you know people with preconceived ideas about organ that I have this record out that I think from what I'm hearing the track that's getting the most airplay—

AN: "Witchcraft."

DW: Yeah, is a standard off the record. Two of ten cuts were standards I think. And one of those standards, because, I mean it works which is great, it has a simple — you know people like hearing standards from the organ and the whole thing. But this band has been very original. The last record we did actually was I think John wrote maybe everything on the record the thing with Lovano and Kenny Wheeler and Mark Feldman. I think there was one track we did a free track.

AN: And there were quite a few free pieces. I mean many people, they look at an organ trio and they think the instrumentation will dictate the conception of the music and oh yeah, man, you guys play a lot of blues or you play a lot of this or a lot of that. Well no we don't. We just, this is the instrumentation but we have our own approach to how we want to play. And we've never really discussed the concept of what we do, we just do it. And we all just listen to each other and whatever happens happens.

MR: Yeah. Is there a point that you can think back that was a good step up into the world of a professional musician, playing with some person or some band and that you felt like I finally got to point where I've been hoping for?

DW: Good question.

MR: I know it's hard to think back.

DW: Who could answer it?

AN: You mean a point where you felt validated?

MR: Yeah I guess you could put it that way.

AN: Well I guess maybe when you have one of your first big gigs, or maybe your first tour or something like that.

MR: Well what was the first big gig for you?

AN: Well the first band that I really worked in I played with, I did a tour with John Scofield in 1978 that was my first European tour, and that was a tour. And then I was working with Dave Liebman in '78. And that was a very, very nurturing experience for me. I was the young blood and I was playing with Dave who'd played with all my heroes, you know, Elvin Jones, Miles Davis and that band also included a fantastic trumpet player from Japan, Terumasa Hino, John Scofield was in that band and eventually it was Ron McClure on bass. So these were all more experienced people than me. And to have that opportunity to play with them was really good and Dave is a great teacher. So for me to be in that situation night after night was very beneficial for me. And then I think having a chance to then work with Stan Getz, that validated me in another sense because a lot of people when they saw me with Dave, that band was a hard hitting band. And a lot of people didn't like what we were doing, maybe we were stretching too much but it was really take no prisoners kind of situation. But then when you play with a master, like Stan, who is acknowledged across the board for his artistry, that validated me in another way. Because then people could see I just wasn't playing with these guys going crazy all the time. We could play a nice bossa nova and things like that, and to play with somebody who played as great as he did was an amazingly great experience for me. You know this guy had an amazing sound, beautiful lines, incredible time, you know, he didn't even know why he sounded as good as he did. He was that kind of natural musician. And that I think gave me another kind of a validation in other circles. But I just consider every experience that I have an opportunity to learn something else about this music. And I consider myself a work in progress.

DW: Yeah, I think a work in progress. I think when I started playing with really great world class musicians who I admired and it worked out between us and I got encouragement from them. You know, which is kind of what you're saying. Steve Grossman, an amazing tenor player, and I'm just thinking about people early on, and Joe Chambers, a very respected drummer/composer and when I was working with Jeremy Steig's band, this was like 20 years ago, and Eddie Gomez playing bass, and these people and they would compliment me or encourage me or whatever, or pull me into another thing, that was definite, that was like saying yeah, okay, I guess I'm doing okay. Okay I'll keep trying. And then probably having, I think the first record that I did under my name and getting really good reviews. Sure there were bad reviews, I'm probably blocking those out. But you know the first time seeing good things in print written, now it doesn't mean anything because I know what I think about it, and if I don't like it which I usually don't but it

doesn't matter what somebody's going to write. But at that time that was a pat on the back, it was saying oh, okay, I guess I'm okay.

AN: I think the biggest thrill is when your mentors tell you that they dig what you're doing. That's the greatest. You know like with the people you look up to who have kind of encouraged you, either directly or just through their divine inspiration, you know, come up to you and go yeah man, you're playing your ass off, or you sound great, or yeah baby. That makes it all worth it.

DW: I think something that made me feel, in a different way, it's really in a different type of music, but it was a real like a nice feeling was I did some touring with Henry Mancini and where he's in his own thing, what a legend. And to be on stage, I mean for him to take me on the road, which he had never done before with a pianist, but to take me on the road and then here I am with the orchestras with full orchestra on stage and hanging out with Henry and we're laughing and we're having fun, that was another kind of — not so much a jazz, a creative music experience, although there was room for that — that made me feel good.

AN: Yeah I mean when people that you've really dug hire you and you get to play with some of your heroes, that's the greatest feeling. I mean to play with people that you've listened to for years and have inspired you and then be on the bandstand with them, that's like wow, what a great feeling. And sometimes you can't believe it, you have to like pinch yourself how'd this happen? And well I've just got to take care of business, stay focused, the bandstand is holy territory, we're all there together, trying to find Kum-ba-ya and everybody work together and find that common language. I mean that's an incredible great feeling. I mean I still get it, when you get to play with somebody you dig, and just try to find like let's just find a common agreement, I mean that's what making music is with people. You try to find the common ground and work together to serve what the music is. So that's — when you get to do it with your heroes, that's a really great feeling.

MR: You've had the opportunity to work with vocalists much and is it different?

DW: Yeah I used to do a lot of work in the 80s with Dakota Staton.

AN: "The Late Show."

DW: Yeah, "The Late Late Show." And I had always loved her records and that was a lot of fun for me to be out doing gigs with her. She didn't drive so a lot of times I would pick her up for the gig or take her back after the gig or something. But musically that was great, and there was another singer, Maxine Sullivan, who I did a record actually also with Maxine that got a lot of nice attention. And that was a lot of fun. Sheila Jordan. My wife is a singer, is a really good singer. We've enjoyed being able to work together all of these years and to write together or do projects. But that's another, you know that's a funny subject too because a lot of musicians are so caught up in looking in one direction

that vocalists, they block this whole concept out. "No I don't want to work with a vocalist," like it's a waste of time. But with the right person it's another zone. You can create incredible things but—

AN: You have to be very sensitive to the situation. I mean you have to respect what the song is. I mean they're trying to sing a lyric. You have to make sure you can always hear that lyric. You have to give them the right kind of support so they can get it out there. And it requires a certain sensitivity. I mean working with Stan Getz was like working with a great singer, because I mean really, the way he could sing out a melody, I mean he was somebody where he didn't even have to improvise on a song. He could just play a ballad and play the melody. You didn't even need to hear him blow on it. He brought a complete life and beautiful expression to just a melody. And you know when you work with a singer you have to be respectful for what they need. You need to support them, but you can't get in their way. I enjoy it. If it's a good singer, I love it.

DW: But then see that's always the thing.

AN: The good singer.

DW: Because yeah well okay what about a horn player? What do you enjoy playing with a bad horn player? That's what I always try to tell people to wake them up, like listen to what you're singing.

AN: It's like when I listen to somebody, somebody goes well you seem to play with a lot of guitar players. Or you seem to play with a lot of this. I say well it's not the instrument that I dig playing with, it's the person who's playing it. Like I'm more concerned with what the person is saying than what the instrument is. I mean what's the person, what's the personality, what's the voice? I mean any great artist on any instrument, any great artist, even visual has a vibe, has a voice. And that's what I listen for. You know what are you saying, what's the story? Not like is it a guitar is it a piano, it's like what are you saying? I mean some singers are great. Some aren't. Some horn players are great. Some aren't. That's a good thing you said that.

MR: I think it's a good point too from the accompanist standpoint that they have to not only bring good music but a good personality to make things cohesive. Get that Kum-ba-ya you were talking about. Right?

DW: I know when I worked with somebody like Al Cohn or Buddy DeFranco or Charlie Rouse, you know you find a way, they play a certain way. They play great. They played great, well Buddy is still living, all in their own ways, but you find a way of interacting with that and if you enjoy the way that you are interacting with it then you have fun working with this person. It doesn't matter if he's playing clarinet. You find Kum-ba-ya.

MR: Is there any kind of, I'll use the word inequality, in the marketing of jazz musicians these days according to their age?

AN: Definitely.

MR: I'll take that as a yes.

AN: That's a long topic to be discussed. I mean unfortunately the way things are going now in this world and with the whole marketing ploy it's like new, exciting, these things are really being pushed through the marketing forces and things like that. And it's very unfortunate because this art form is something where the longer you can stay at it, the better you're going to get at it, and it's very sad to see many artists who are at the peak of their game getting ignored for one reason or another, because they're not the new kid on the block or they don't look a certain way, or things like that. And that's quite unfortunate. And there's a lot of guys that are in the, I'd say in the middle zone, who have been kind of ignored unfortunately. It's like if you're new and young and exciting that's one thing. Or if you're old and like an old tiger, it's like young lions, old tigers. What about just the herd that's in there? What about just the cats that are in there in the middle? There's a — pretty across the board there's been a lot of people that have not really been getting a fair shake and I'm not really sure why that is, it seems maybe in the whole reality of marketing and the world today and just our society, there's not a lot of room for a lot of people to be able to get out there as far as being supported. It's like I look at it, there's several getting a very big piece of the pie. And many others have to grovel for their small slice, which is unfortunate. Would you agree with that.

DW: Yeah, oh absolutely. And you know it's also a little unfortunate for the young artists that get all of this attention.

AN: Where they gonna go?

DW: Yeah where are they gonna go, and I also think, in a lot of cases how much further they could go if they were left in some peace to really look for their own voice, like I was saying earlier, to keep pushing for it. Because all of a sudden at this age where they're really still developing they're in the middle of marketing strategy by record label and you know you need to do this and your next thing needs to be this, and now we know that you can play that way but we need to market you this way, and all of a sudden you're in the middle of a whole corporate concept as opposed to really having some peace and maybe still being a little hungry for a while, and developing even more out of your playing. Finding yourself more.

AN: That's a really good point.

MR: Yeah, then all of a sudden you're elevated to this status and you're just like almost a beginner in the field.

AN: Right, yeah. And that whole mentoring situation doesn't seem to be existing that much now. And I mean I remember when I was always the young guy in the band. I was always the baby. And now I'm in certain situations where I'm the old man, but then I'm still in

situations where I am the young guy. And I play with James Moody, he's 76 now, he's playing better than ever. And you know it, I don't even think he has a record deal now, and he's one of the real icons of the music, and one of the last of the survivors and he's at the peak of his game, and he doesn't even have a deal now. Because I think he was with a big company and they were saying well we want you to do this, we want you to do that.

MR: Exactly. I remember him saying that.

AN: Man, I mean come on, this is James Moody, can't you at least let the guy make a record he wants to make? I mean it's — we could go on about this for a long time. But your question is a very good one. It's true, what you're saying.

MR: What about the racial scene these days? Is it, I mean this music has brought a lot of people together where they weren't allowed in other parts of society. Is it healthy now for you guys anyway?

AN: You know I've never really thought about this stuff in regard to what I do. I just do what I do. I can only try to be the best that I can be. I'm going to be — sorry about that — I know I'm going to be involved in situations and I can only try to play the best I can. I know I won't get hired by certain white musicians. I know I won't get hired by certain black musicians. But you know what? Then I know I get hired by certain white musicians and I know I get hired by black musicians. And I've found that it's a strange reality but being a white jazz drummer, there's not many of me. There's not many. You know what I'm saying? And I mean there are certain white guys that won't hire me because I'm white. There's certain white people within the business that won't hire me because I'm white. And you know I find that the best musicians that I know, black or white, they don't look at you, they listen to you. But I don't let this bother me because I can just go straight ahead and play. So that's BS for other people to worry about, not me. I just have to go ahead and play my ass off and do the best that I can do. But I understand the reality of it. And I don't let it faze me. You know people like Art Pepper and all these guys that wrote these books, they were always dealing with that paranoia, you know, oh will I be accepted in this game as this, because I'm going to feel like an outsider. Man, I'm in here with what I'm doing. I don't worry about that. You know he was always dealing with that and that kind of paranoia and then — I can't worry about those kind of things. I have friends, black, white, green, you know we're all the same here, we're all the same in this world. If people could start looking at how similar we all are instead of how different we are, you know we're all the same man, we can all get together, black men, white women, white men, black women, yellow people. It makes no difference. We're all people. We can all get together. It's not like humans and dogs, you know what I mean? We're all people in this world. Right? I mean if they could all look at it that way, if we could look at things that way there'd be no more problems happening in Europe with the whole thing

with Yugoslavia and Serbia and this and Croatia and all the Middle Eastern crap. You know I just look at the common — what do we all have in common. Not what do we all have in difference. I don't know, what would you say about all that?

DW: Oh yeah, and you know there's nothing in there to argue with. I'm not going to argue with you anyway.

AN: But I mean I don't worry about this stuff man.

DW: Yeah that's something that you can't, you know, it's like if someone is — really it's kind of like going back talking about corporate marketing. If somebody is so hung up on this preconceived idea rather than just looking or listening rather at the way someone plays and says yeah I'd like to work with him, I'd like to have him in my band or I hear the way he plays and I don't want to have him in my band, that's what it should all be about. And if someone doesn't happen to think or hear that way then I don't think I would want to work with them anyway. I wouldn't really want to be a part of that musical situation. So I never think about it, it all just seems to work out in a natural way.

AN: I mean when I first came to New York I was playing with just a broad cross section of everybody on a racial basis. And it wasn't about what you looked like it was like if you could play, you had the desire, you had the love, and you were giving to the music. And people were listening with their ears, not with their eyes.

MR: And now?

AN: I think it's probably the same way. I'm sure that I don't worry about it. I just don't worry about it. It's like if a guy wants to hire me I'm there for the music. I go in, I try to do the best I can for what the situation warrants. Hopefully when people hire me they trust me to bring forth what I can do. And I'm there for the good of the music. And I try to get along with everybody, there we go again, Kum-ba-ya baby, that's what you want. That's what it's all supposed to be. You know music is supposed to be a thing where we all get together and all that other stuff is not supposed to interfere. It may all affect the way people think about stuff and their viewpoints, but when you get on the bandstand man, the music, it tells you what to do. That's the common denominator. And we're all supposed to work together for that. I mean that's the bottom line.

MR: Right. Well said. Let's suppose you got asked to do a career day at a local high school and would you be encouraging to some aspiring musicians to try to make a living in this day and age?

GW: Yeah well that's an interesting comment because I was walking down the hall of Oberlin where I teach and I was listening to all of these people play this phenomenal, you know like I wish I could play the piano like this, it's just ridiculous, and you have a violinist over here, and I was thinking what are they all going to do? Oh my gosh. But at the same time when I'm sitting in a room working with the pianist that I have, I'm not going to

give them that vibe and who knows what they can do until they get out there and try. I'm going to try to get them better. I'm going to sit there and play with them and work on their reaction time and work on their ears and try to play something back to them that they fall apart trying to play back to me so they'll get better. So that they'll go out there and see what they can do. Because that's really what, you know I think that's a big problem sometimes with say families where you have the family negative influence in saying, "Don't go into music you'll never make a living. Come into the family business. Be a doctor." Well how do you know you can't make a living? Don't tell them that, tell them check it out but do it like a hundred percent. And then see what you can do. Or suppose they want to be an actor or a painter or whatever. And then later then it's going to become pretty clear which way you're going to have to go. Either it's going to work or it's not and you're going to adjust to it.

MR: Right. You said you came from an artistic family. Did you get any — can I assume you got encouragement?

AN: Yes I did. My parents both were very pragmatic in the regard to my father was a fine artist. He never made his living as an artist. He made his living doing technical illustration so he still utilized his craft but not to the sense of expression that he was able to do. And my mother had been involved with acting and then she got involved, because of her aesthetic viewpoint, got involved with graphic design and advertising. So both of them didn't really make their living at what their passion was. So they were both very concerned because of what their reality had been, with me being properly prepared to have something to fall back on. So consequently they said look, I mean originally I went to school at Emerson College for one year to study liberal arts. But I was getting so into playing, I said what am I doing, I might as well put my focus in more towards the music. They just wanted me to be prepared for the tactics of this world we live in. But I think that — I never finished school, I just started getting out there and playing. So I mean I know that I gave them a great amount of satisfaction knowing that I have been somehow able to eke out a living playing music. And it's not easy. I mean I'm traveling all the time because I just can't stay home and do it. It's kind of like a blessing and a curse. I mean the blessing is being able to go out and play music with great people. Every night is an adventure. You never know what's going to happen. The curse is I have to be away from my family a lot, got a lot of miles on me, can't stay home on a regular basis, but I don't think I could do anything else. It's kind of like I need it. And I don't think I made a conscious decision to become a musician. It was just, it just kind of happened. You know I loved doing it, people call you, they get your number, you go to the gig, you get another gig. You know it just seemed to happen that way and if you are really trying to think intelligently and realistically, man, go out and get a job where you know you can make a

steady check. If a young person is debating in their mind, well should I go for the security or should I go out and try it, well you know if you're having to think about it then maybe you're not supposed to be doing it. I mean with me I just kind of look at it as though this kind of happened. I guess it kind of picked me. And I had to go with it, so I did. And I mean if you're young and you're not sure about it and you have no responsibilities and you can just go out there and give it a shot, give it a shot. Try. See what's going to happen. Once you have the realities of marriage, mortgage, children, all that, you may not have that opportunity to give it a shot.

MR: Well I'm sure both of you guys are putting a lot away towards retirement.

AN: What am I going to retire to? What am I going to retire to? That's the great thing. I mean I look at James Moody, he's 76. I talked to Pat LaBarbara today, he's going to go out and play with Elvin again. You know Elvin is 73. These guys are only getting better. What are they going to do go play golf? I mean they're still getting better. I mean that's the great thing about being a musician. It's like every day I look forward to playing because there's going to be something different than the day before. I mean I got no pension plan with my job, we're out there in the real world. Anything we do is IRAs or whatever kind of stuff. It's like man, I don't know what I would retire to.

DW: I hate to think what you would retire to, really. I wouldn't want to be around.

AN: Man. I'm just hoping my mind and body can keep it together.

DW: Yeah but you know that's the thing about music, like you're talking about Moody and everybody. If you look at what music can do for you, in terms of years, and you see people that are like 72 years old and they look good and they're happy, and they're happy because they're playing.

AN: And this is their life force.

DW: That's exactly it, yeah.

AN: Look at Milt Hinton, how long was Milt, what was he 90 or something?

MR: He was 90, yeah.

AN: I mean man this guy, he just kept going. And he always had a smile on his face, and he brought a great vibe to everybody, and he just kept doing it and I mean he had it together for a long time. I mean he was playing up 'till he was around 87, 88, right?

MR: Right.

AN: God bless him.

DW: If you look at a lot of other people in other lines of work and they have ulcers and they're stressed out at like 60 and they're burned out and they're miserable. It's a big difference. If you're the person that finds that they should be playing music to make you happy, you're not going to play it to get rich. Hopefully you're going to make an okay living and

all that stuff but if that's really in you that this is what you do, that can keep you going for a lot of years.

AN: I feel like I'm just starting to get the hang of it now. I really do. I feel like in the past year or so I'm starting to get a clearer idea. I mean this is after doing it a long time. And that's a great feeling, because it keeps me hungry, keeps me humble, and keeps me like vibrant.

DW: It's a constant challenge, which is a good thing.

MR: And it can't be — what you're talking about can't be because of your technique I wouldn't think.

AN: What technique?

MR: Well okay.

DW: You're talking to the wrong people here about that.

MR: I mean it's something else, right? It's making connections between players, and I mean I don't know what. But maybe we can't describe it but you're feeling it in the last year or so you said.

AN: I just feel like I'm getting a better idea about music and projecting that other thing which can't really be described or explained. You know it's not a technical thing. It's not necessarily an intellectual thing. It's more a vibe that's being created and maybe you want to call it a spiritual kind of feeling. But projecting a feeling and having people being able to feel something through the music. I mean I realize that recently this is a gift if you can play music and get out there and play for people. You have a certain amount of gift. That maybe you just God dropped it in your lap or maybe you've spent a lot time working at the craft to have this gift. And then when you get out you're trying to make people feel something hopefully. Any great artist is going to do that to you in any field of music and any kind of art idiom. Picasso could do it, Rembrandt could do it, Ben Webster could do it with one note, John Coltrane could do it with a thousand notes. You know what I'm saying? And Jimi Hendrix could do it. Marvin Gaye could do it. You get a vibe. You get a feeling. Billie Holiday.

DW: Humphrey Bogart.

AN: You name it. Humphrey Bogart. Greta Garbo.

MR: Yeah. That's, you know that's so true. Like Humphrey did it with like his look or a look.

DW: Yeah, the dark thing, yeah.

MR: Someone else did it with a note.

AN: That's right. And to have that kind of thing where you make people get some kind of feeling. That's something. And as you grow up in this world, as you start to deal with life and the things that you have to deal with as far as realities of life, you know, wife, kids, family, being out here in the world working with everybody, you know all these things effect you. You know everything that happens to you effects you. You know people you

love, people that come and go, people that die, whatever. All these things effect you. And they all help to shape you and when you play this is all part of your life experience. And this is all part of what's out there on the line. And when you're playing you've got to be thankful for that experience. You've got to get out there and play your ass off. You could be dead tomorrow. You can't feel like you're jiving anybody. You're on the line. It's for real. And when you're in a great band it's a great feeling because if everybody's got that kind of feeling going on it's a great thing. It's an indescribable thing. You know there are those moments in your life where you feel like the music is playing you. You're just like a vehicle for stuff that comes out when you're in that other space. And those are the things that keep you going.

DW: But it's definitely not a technical thing. I mean you have to have enough technique to convey, to be able to manifest this thing that's happening, but technique is — nothing against technique — but it has to be up to a certain level but it's definitely not a technical thing.

AN: I mean you hear Trane, I'm aware of the feeling. I'm not aware of the amazing chops that he had to do it. It's like you hear a man really playing from his soul. I mean to me, it's like any of the great players I hear, whatever technical brilliance they have, you never lose the blues. The blues is always somehow there in any of the people that you dig. I mean you heard it all the time with Louis Armstrong. You hear it with Billie Holiday. You hear it with Trane. You hear it with Sonny. You hear it with somebody that makes you feel something. And that's the thing that I, I mean it's not even just jazz it's all the other music too. Jimi Hendrix, with all the stuff he did pushing the envelope with the guitar. Man, underneath it that was some serious blues going down. When I hear Rubenstein playing Chopin nocturnes, you're getting it. I mean you feel it. And that's, for me that's all the stuff that's effected me. It's like how does it make you feel? It's not like did you see that? Well no, it's like wow—

MR: Did you feel that.

AN: And how did you like it. It's not like how are you doing, it's like how are you feeling?

MR: Well I know you fellas have to get to a sound check.

AN: Yeah but we could probably go on —

DW: We'll just hang here.

MR: We'll hang here.

AN: Do you have any other pertinent questions?

MR: Well let me think about that for a moment. Do you have like a list, a short list of people that you haven't played with yet that you'd just love to? Or maybe even people have passed on that —

DW: Oh boy.

MR: Well there you go.

AN: That's a big list. I mean I wish I'd been able to see people like Bird, Bud Powell, I mean Coltrane. Because the energy and the feeling you get from the recorded medium is phenomenal but that never approaches what it's like to be in the room. I mean when you're in the room with the sound it changes your life forever. I mean the first time I heard Miles Davis is was like, or the first time you, like I remember the first time I sat next to Philly Joe Jones and it was like oh man. Those things, you never forget that, and being able to have heard Bird or these cats, Bud. My God, what an amazing experience. And to get to play with them would have been an astounding treat.

DW: What you just said about being in the room, that's the thing right there. Not a record, not a CD, but being in the room. Like I would love to have been sitting somewhere in a room where Tatum was playing.

AN: Yeah, wow.

DW: That would have been unbelievable. It would have been just unbelievable because that's kind of like going back to my uncle playing the piano, there could have been nothing better than being in the room, hearing this right here. There's no separation, no second generation or anything. Nothing like it. Which is an important thing for the educational system to realize is that to really develop great young players they need to be in the room.

AN: They need to be in the room with the sound.

DW: That's right.

AN: I mean I can't stress it enough. To be in the room and hear somebody that really plays great. To be next to them. To be in the room with the sound and experience it first hand.

DW: Because that's reality.

AN: Yeah, that's reality. It's like I make the analogy a lot of times when I'm doing a clinic, I'll say well do you just want to read the sex manual and look at the videos? Or do you want to be right in there and enjoy that.

MR: That gets their attention I bet.

AN: That gets their attention. But you've got to be there. I mean there's nothing like being on the bandstand playing with it. But to be in the room, to be a drummer and to watch how this motion makes the sound. To feel what's going on. To see how the horn player plays. To watch their whole physical being and to feel the sound. I mean I was deceived for many years when I used to listen to records, because whenever I used to hear Stan Getz on a record he had that soft, gentle tone. And then I would hear Joe Henderson on a record, and he had this really firm core on his sound. So I'm thinking Joe's got this real big sound, and Stan has got this gentle sound. Then I got on the bandstand with Joe and it was a small, he's not loud, not loud at all, but he had a very firm core to his sound. Meantime Stan Getz, it sounded like he was so quiet, this was like a foghorn. I mean the

ability of his sound to project was like getting hit with a hammer wrapped in velvet. I mean he was so loud. It was deceptive. You'd never get that from a record. You'd never get it. And like when I first heard Thelonious Monk live I could not believe how much sound he got out of the piano without banging. It was like there was mac trucks behind each finger putting out the sound. Astounding.

DW: Yeah I remember that too, the first time I heard Monk at the Vanguard. Because that's a good example of drawing a sound out of the instrument. It's not done with force and attack and this and that. He was pulling the sound out. Or hearing Elvin live the first time.

AN: Yeah I mean you can't believe it. You just can't believe being in that room. I mean and whenever there's an opportunity I think for young musicians to go out, go out and see the old guys first. Because they're not going to be around forever. I mean you will never forget it.

MR: Plus you're not seeing any of the — when you listen to a record you're not seeing any of the body language and the eye contact and the way the music is shaped from the start of the song to the end.

DW: Sure. If you're in the room, that's when I said it's reality. You're in the room, this is it, this is the whole picture, the complete picture is delivered to you.

AN: Right. I mean and when you feel that amazing feeling from records, the records we all know and love that have helped to shape our whole reality as far as the way we perceive music and play, if you get that vibe from a record, imagine what it must have been like live. I mean so I can't, it's really important for young musicians to not just look at the books and look at the videos, but whenever there's a chance, go out and see the cats play. There's nothing like it. I mean I remember seeing Dizzy when I was eight years old. It was amazing. And he was amazing because he was just such a silly person and a great life force coming from this guy. I don't even remember the music, I just remember this guy being so much fun and clowning around with me. Because the effect, the positive effect that that had on me as a kid made me then think about the music and like wow, this was something that gave me a great feeling. And then later on I was listening and I realized this guy was also a phenomenal musician but I just remembered him, as the human being, and just his vibe. And years later I was fortunate and I got to hang with Dizzy a bunch and I got to know him a little bit, and then I finally did get to play with him. And I said man you know when I was eight years old I saw you play and it was at this gig at Leonard Bernstein's house for the NAACP, a benefit, in like the 60s. And Wes Montgomery was there, Morgana King, Milt was there, Billy Taylor, and Dizzy was there. And there was no bandstand, they were just set up like on a platform. So I'm this little curly red-haired kid, right by the drums, always watching. And Dizzy was clowning with me, and all this stuff. And I just remembered what a good time I had. And how he

just made me feel so good. And it was a great thing. And I guess that was one of those experiences that was kind of defining. Although I would never have known it at the time. Years later I said man, and he was like okay. It's a great thing.

MR: I can see that, watching his face and like woah.

AN: But you remember these things as time goes on, and the people that you admire and then you get to meet them as people and some of them are fantastic human beings and they are kind of like the way the music is, and other people it's another world the way they are. And that's all part of it too. Where maybe their real self comes through the music.

MR: What's it like trying to juggle schedules? When I look at kind of what you're doing, you're doing some teaching, both of you seem to, and playing with all these different people. Do your commitments collide?

DW: Well I'm not on the road like Adam.

AN: I kind of cut loose.

DW: You're talking about the road warrior here.

AN: I kind of cut loose my teaching for right now because I didn't feel that I could fulfill what students should be getting. I mean when a kid is in school and they want to have a lesson every week, I wasn't able to fulfill that. And I used to tell them up front look, I can't see you every week, I'm going to be out for a few weeks then we can get together for two, three hours at a shot. I was realizing that that was not fair to them. Some of them said, "Oh no I still want to do it." And you know if somebody still really wants to get together with me they can call me and I can try to do it, but I haven't, right now, been committed to any of the schools that I was in the past. I'm still an adjunct as such. But it gets difficult. And then it gets difficult with commitments, because sometimes you'll say to somebody yeah, I'll do this. And somebody else you want to play with calls you and it's like well I'm sorry but I am committed at that time. Because I'd like to be a man of my word.

MR: Yeah. You start backing out too often—

AN: Yeah I don't like to do that. I mean I had the situation of sending subs in on situations and eventually they just say okay, well you're not available, we're going to use him. A risk you take. So right now I'm really not actively teaching. I do clinics and things like that when I'm out on the road or I'll do some private students and things like that. And I enjoy doing them, especially when you have people who have a certain degree of ability already. Because then you can kind of help them fine tune things and it helps me fine tune things too.

DW: But it does get tricky because this past year I've really gotten into a lot of college stuff that is all very enjoyable and very good but it is tricky actually doing two colleges for one thing, and then playing. Because the playing will conflict with the colleges. The colleges

will conflict with the playing. Sometimes both colleges will conflict with each other. And then I always feel bad about, it's really all about, what I try to do is to try to keep some kind of balance. To try to be fair. To like these students here, these people are really not at the level of these people here but you still have to be fair. Is this a gig — this gig is going to conflict with that. Is this gig really that important? Maybe not. Okay, I can't do the gig because this educational event I have to give priority to. Or vice versa. I have to go out of town and play something, okay. Have to cancel all this and then you have to reschedule and find ways of making it fair for everybody. So it's really, it gets into a lot. There's a way to do it. That can border on some stress at times.

AN: Try to keep the balance. Try to keep the balance.

DW: And take niacin.

MR: And take?

DW: Niacin. Stress.

AN: Trying to find the balance. That's not easy. But it's necessary.

DW: Yeah. Trying to be fair and a lot of people don't think that way. They really don't care if they're fair or not they just basically go for it. But if you're dealing with students and people who you are trying — you know you're trying to help them. You're trying to be fair to them and to the people that are, that want you to be there, to help them.

MR: Well listen fellas, this has been great for me.

AN: You ask very good questions.

DW: Yeah, very good.

MR: So we'll look down the road to do it again, and when you've got a little more experience under your belt. A few more airports.

AN: That's it, no problem. No problem. Thanks.

MR: Thank you.

DW: A pleasure Monk, thank you.